

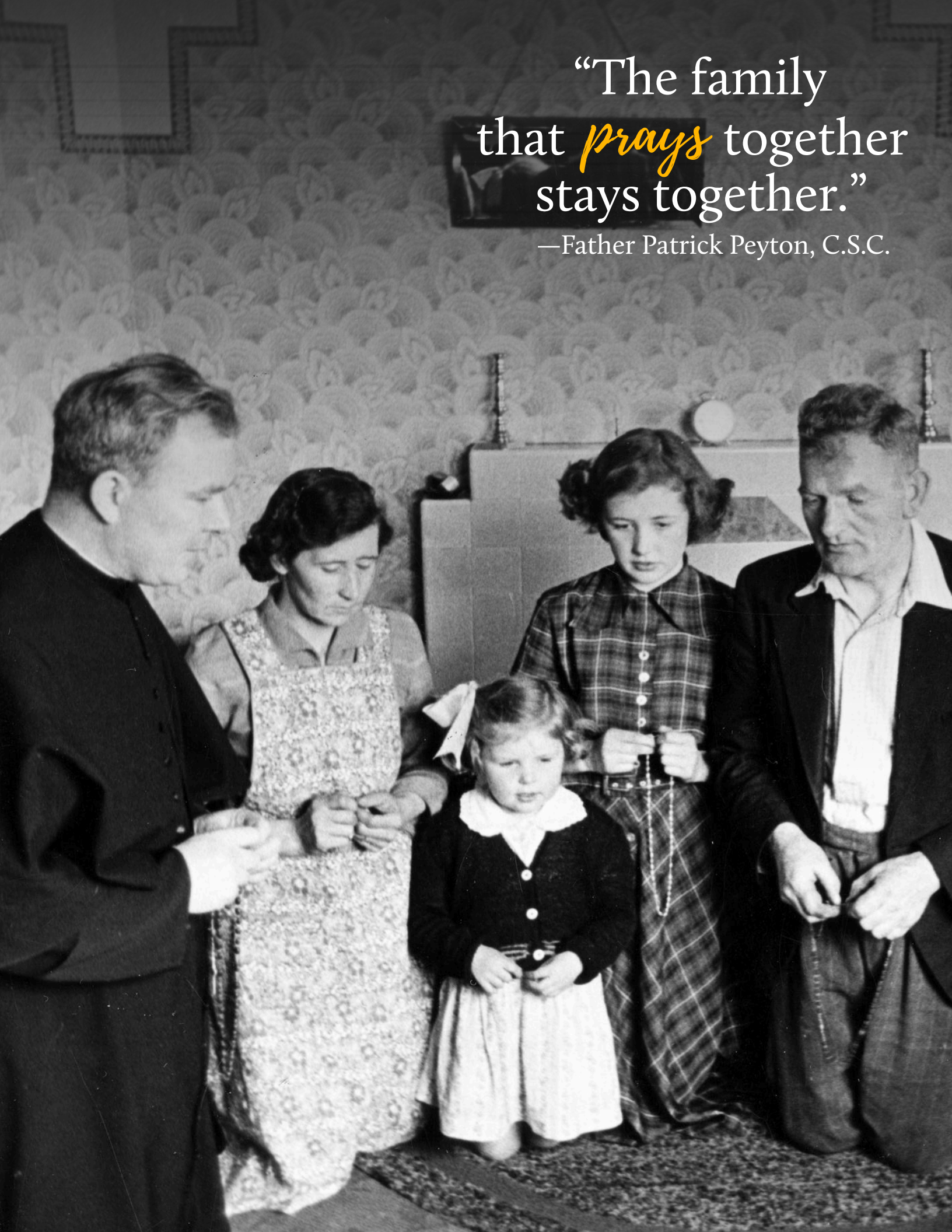
TAKE ACTION
25 small revolutions to begin this week
FEATURE
The good news about creation
FOR THE TABLE
5 questions for your dinner tonight

HOLY CROSS FAMILY MINISTRIES

Laudato Si' and Your Family

A Call to Care for Our Common Home

Rev. Fred Jenga, C.S.C. · Meigs Turgeon


"The family
that prays together
stays together."
—Father Patrick Peyton, C.S.C.

What's inside.

INTRO	Introduction *The complete introduction by Rev. Fred Jenga, C.S.C. and Meigs Turgeon.*	05
PART I	The Gospel of Creation *Dominion is not domination — what the Bible actually teaches.*	08
PART II	The Spiritual Roots of the Crisis *Individualism, consumerism, and the desire for power.*	13
PART III	The Call to Integral Ecology *Everything is connected — including your family.*	22
PART IV	Your Family's Contribution *5 reflection questions · 25 small revolutions · plus HCFM family resources.*	29
HCFM	How To Begin Your Family Rosary Tonight. *A resource from us!*	32
ACTIONS	Ways Your Family Can Embrace Integral Ecology *25 small revolutions.*	33

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AN URGENT CHALLENGE

The urgent challenge to protect our common home includes a concern to bring the whole *human family* together to seek a sustainable and integral development, for we know that things can change. The Creator does not abandon us; He never forsakes His loving plan or repents of having created us. Humanity still has the ability to work together in building our common home.

POPE FRANCIS · *LAUDATO SI'* 13

INTRODUCTION

A letter to families, on the care of our common home.

In 2015, Pope Francis published his landmark encyclical *Laudato Si'* : On Care for Our Common Home. This encyclical letter, addressed to the Catholic faithful and people of good will around the world, is an urgent call for humanity to take swift action in response to the unfolding ecological crisis that is causing so much harm to God's creation. Recognizing the urgent nature of the crisis and the Church's obligation to be the light of the world in every generation, the Holy Father's message is simple: people of faith must act now to protect our common home from further destruction.

Laudato Si' (which means in Latin "Praise be to You") was the first papal encyclical to address the ecological crisis as its primary focus, providing Catholics with a reminder that our faith comes with strong ecological commitments. In it, Pope Francis demonstrates that concern for the environment is not at all opposed to the convictions of Christian faith, but is rather informed and enriched by them. At the heart of *Laudato Si's* ecological message is the biblical revelation that God has given the earth to the human race as a gift that He has called us to preserve and steward in His name. As disciples of Jesus, Christians have a special obligation to protect life, to care for God's creation, and to ensure that our common home is stewarded and preserved for our children and grandchildren.

FROM THE ENCYCLICAL

"The urgent challenge to protect our common home includes a concern to bring the whole human family together to seek a sustainable and integral development."

POPE FRANCIS · LS 13

Pope Francis' call to care for our common home extends to the entire Church and to the world at large. As the most basic and essential unit of the Church and of society, the family has a particularly important role to play in stewarding God's gift of creation. In "Laudato Si' and Your Family: A Call to Care for Our Common Home.", we would like to encourage families around the world to take up Pope Francis' call to action on behalf of God's creation and the common good.

— Continued on page six

INTRODUCTION

This booklet is divided into four sections. The first section, The Gospel of Creation, explores the theology and spirituality at the heart of *Laudato Si'* message, helping your family understand why care for our common home is an important commitment of our Catholic faith. The second section, The Spiritual Roots of the Crisis, takes a look at *Laudato Si'* understanding of the deeper problems that lie at the heart of the ecological crisis. The third section, The Call to Integral Ecology, explores Pope Francis' proposed solution to the ecological crisis. Finally, the last section, Your Family's Contribution: Stewardship, Service, and Spirituality, explores the ways that your family can respond to *Laudato Si'* call to action, with a special emphasis on how joining together for stewardship and service can unite your family, strengthen your spiritual lives, and provide unexpected opportunities for family prayer.

While this booklet is designed for parents, we hope that its core messages will be shared with children in a way that is appropriate to their age. And if they are old enough, encourage them to read it, too! All of the activities recommended can (and should) be done as a family.

It is our prayer that this booklet will inspire your family to a deeper appreciation of God's creation and the ways that stewardship of our common home can unite your family in faith and service. The Lord has blessed us with a beautiful home to share with each other and with His other creatures. Let's take care of it together so our children and grandchildren can enjoy the beauty of God's handiwork. May God bless you and your families.

IN CHRIST · THE AUTHORS



REV. FRED JENGA, C.S.C.
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AT THE HEART OF THIS MINISTRY

A CALL TO FAMILY PRAYER

VENERABLE PATRICK PEYTON, C.S.C.

The family that prays together *stays together.*

HCFM



THE GOOD NEWS ABOUT THE EARTH

Every creature is a "message" from God.

"Every created thing, whether a dog, a rose, a mountain, or the sea, is a 'message' from God that tells us of His goodness, His beauty, and His love."

DOMINION, NOT DOMINATION

What the Gospel of *Creation* is all about.

At the heart of Pope Francis' message to the Church in *Laudato Si'* is the conviction that faith has a serious contribution to make in discussions about the ecological crisis. In particular, the Christian contribution to the larger discussion is rooted in the theology of creation that emerges from the Bible, which Francis calls "the Gospel of Creation" — the good news about the earth and its creatures in light of God. The entire second chapter of *Laudato Si'* is an exploration of the theology of creation found in the Bible, with a special focus on how the Scriptures can inform our understanding of the value of the earth and its creatures as well as our responsibility to care for them.

> *The earth is the Lord's, and everything in it.*
> PSALM 24:1

At the core of the Gospel of Creation is the joyful declaration of David in the psalms: *"The earth is the Lord's and all that is in it"* (Psalm 24:1). Any proper understanding of the earth and our place on it must start here, with the realization that our planet and its creatures are the good creation of God. Seeing that the earth was good, and that human beings were "very good," God entrusted the care of the planet to humans as His representatives (Genesis 1:1-31). However, God did not give us free reign over the earth; rather, He commanded us to "have dominion" over it (Genesis 1:28) and to "till and keep" the garden of creation (Genesis 2:15).

In his exploration of these two commandments, Pope Francis explains that "dominion" is not to be confused with "domination." On the contrary, dominion means *responsible stewardship* — we are called to take care of creation on behalf of God, to represent Him and His care to all creatures (LS 116). Francis also notes that the language of "tilling" and "keeping" implies a twofold commitment: humans are free to cultivate the earth, using its resources and making it bear fruit for the common good ("tilling"), but we are also called to protect and preserve the earth as its overseers ("keeping") (LS 67).



NOT ONE WILL FALL

God cares for human and sparrow alike. Nothing escapes His providential love.

· GOD LOVES ALL THINGS THAT EXIST WISDOM 11:24 · *LAUDATO SI'* 77

Unfortunately, sin has caused us to see creation as something to control and dominate for our own purposes rather than as something to protect and steward for the common good. The earth and its creatures are valued not for their intrinsic worth as creations of God, but for their usefulness to human beings. Pope Francis argues that we have made living things into objects to use rather than subjects to appreciate.

Christian theology has a different vision. It resists this trend to see other creatures as objects, instead affirming that all of creation is loved by God for its own sake. The Book of Wisdom summarizes this well when it says of God, *"For You love all things that exist, and detest none of the things that You have made; for You would not have made anything if You had hated it"* (Wisdom 11:24). Pope Francis explains, *"Every creature is the object of the Father's tenderness... Even the fleeting life of the least of beings is the object of His love, and in its few seconds of existence, God enfolds it with His affection"* (LS 77).

As Jesus affirms, God cares for human and sparrow alike (cf. Matthew 10:29-31; Luke 12:6-7). He clothes the lilies of the field and feeds the birds of the air, ensuring that nothing escapes His providential care (cf. Matthew 6:25-33; Luke 12:22-31). God's command to show love and concern to others extends even to oxen, donkeys, and birds, too (cf. Deuteronomy 22:4,6; Exodus 23:12)! This means that Christians cannot simply disregard the well-being of other creatures, but must attend to them with compassion and good will as their stewards and caretakers. This has major implications in any discussion about care for our common home.



FEATURE · LAUDATO SI' 34

An *irreplaceable* and irretrievable beauty.

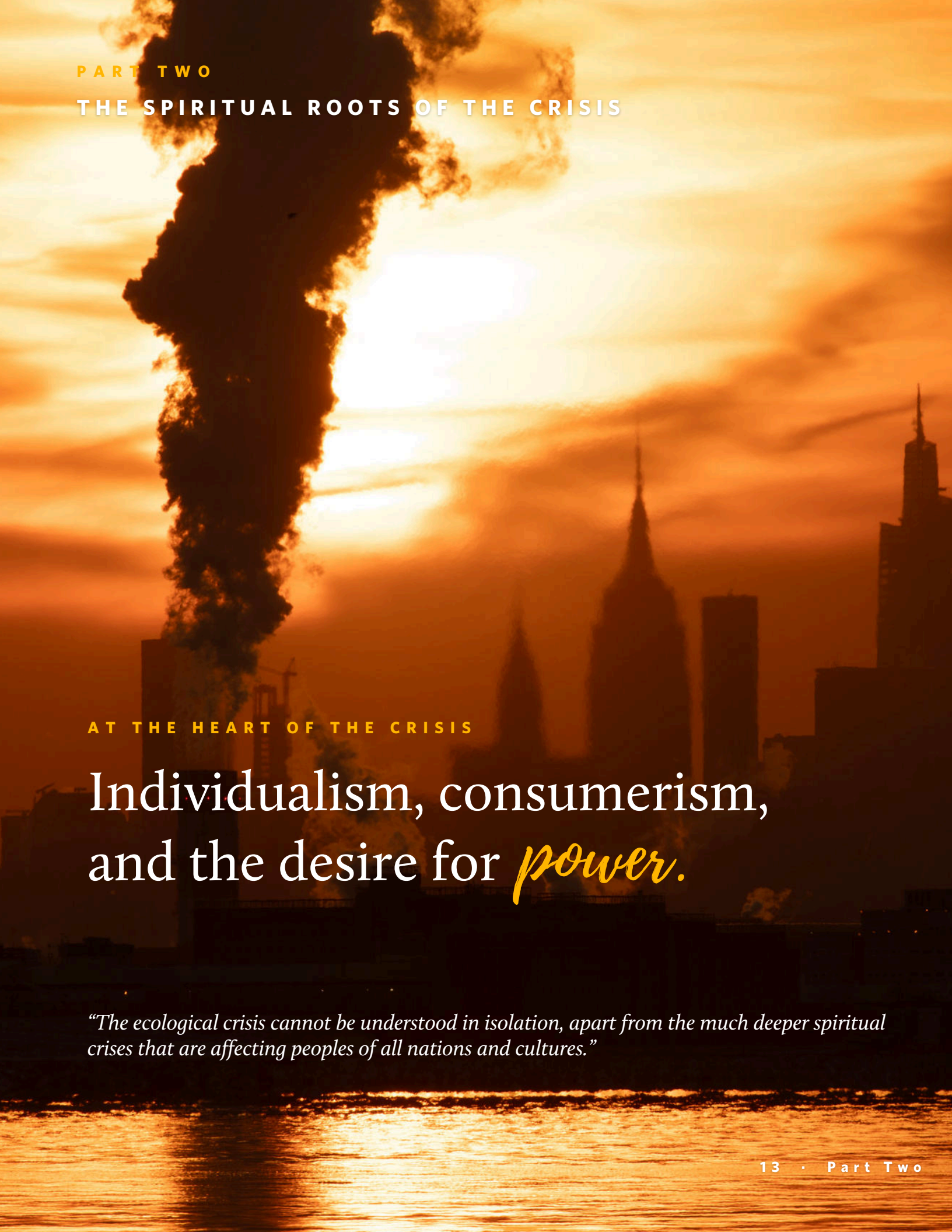
"When the earth is destroyed, the great symphony of creation's praise goes silent."

Apart from the Bible's insistence that God cares for all His creatures, there is another essential reason why we cannot abandon the earth and its creatures to harm and destruction. Part of the good news about creation, Pope Francis argues, is that it speaks to us about God, revealing something about His mind and His heart. The natural world has something to teach us; every created thing, whether a dog, a rose, a mountain, or the sea, is a *"message"* from God that tells us of His goodness, His beauty, and His love. Just as God has revealed Himself to us in the Scriptures, so too He has revealed Himself in His creatures, each of which helps us to see His brilliance.

Every creature is an "irreplaceable and irretrievable beauty" that, once lost, can never be replaced.

POPE FRANCIS · LAUDATO SI'34

Because of this, Pope Francis describes each creature as an "irreplaceable and irretrievable beauty" that, once lost, can never be replaced (LS 34). When the earth is destroyed, the great symphony of creation's praise goes silent. Christ commanded the Church to proclaim the gospel to the ends of the earth, so that all humanity would be brought to praise the Blessed Trinity. We must allow the rest of creation to continue its hymn of praise to God, too, without interrupting the song or silencing the chorus. We can do this only by attending to the *"cry of the earth,"* which calls us to act decisively as its stewards and caretakers (LS 49).



AT THE HEART OF THE CRISIS

Individualism, consumerism, and the desire for *power.*

"The ecological crisis cannot be understood in isolation, apart from the much deeper spiritual crises that are affecting peoples of all nations and cultures."

THE ROOTS RUN DEEPER THAN THE SYMPTOMS

A spiritual crisis behind the *ecological* one.

Like all of the social teachings of the Church, *Laudato Si'* sees spiritual significance behind the great issues facing humanity. Throughout the encyclical, Pope Francis makes it clear that the ecological crisis cannot be understood in isolation, apart from the much deeper spiritual crises that are affecting peoples of all nations and cultures. At its core, the crisis affecting the environment has its roots in human attitudes and behaviors. Over half of *Laudato Si'* is dedicated to looking at these deeper spiritual issues that have given rise to the ecological crisis facing our planet.

The key to understanding Pope Francis' diagnosis of the problem, as well as his proposed solutions, is found in the following phrase: *"The human environment and the natural environment deteriorate together; we cannot adequately combat environmental degradation unless we attend to causes related to human and social degradation"* (LS 48). The Holy Father does not believe that the environmental crisis can be solved simply by tweaking our economies, using less plastic, or transitioning away from fossil fuels. On the contrary, he thinks there can be no lasting change without first paying attention to the things that have contributed to the deterioration of human relationships and society at large.

Though there are many lesser issues that he discusses, we can identify three major issues that are at the heart of the current crisis: *individualism*, *consumerism*, and the *desire for power and control*. Let's briefly look at each before moving on to Pope Francis' suggested solution.

The *human* environment and the natural environment *deteriorate together;* we cannot adequately combat environmental degradation unless we attend to causes related to human and social degradation.



POPE FRANCIS
LAUDATO SI' 48

WHEN I BECOME MORE IMPORTANT THAN OTHERS

The "me first" culture — and *its* cost.

Modern society has been defined by a preoccupation with the concerns of the individual, often to the detriment of the larger human family. In other words, most people have a tendency to focus on and prioritize themselves at the expense of others. The modern mindset has overwhelmingly focused on "me": my desires, my concerns, my comfort, my life, my will. These have become the determining factors in our decision making, both at the level of the individual and in society at large.

Practically, this attitude makes us inattentive to others, aloof to the needs or desires of anyone apart from ourselves. The result is that we have stopped recognizing human dignity, since anything that does not directly interest us seems to be irrelevant to our lives.

This has led to what Pope Francis calls a "throwaway culture," which is defined by the tendency to discard things — and people — that do not seem to have any particular usefulness (LS 22).

This type of individualism, which is marked by self-centeredness and inattentiveness to others, has been adopted by humanity as a whole. Environmental degradation is just one effect of the larger problem; this "me first" culture has also led to the embrace of abortion, discrimination against the disabled, and neglect of the elderly. When humanity as a species lives this attitude, the result is a human-centered view of the world in which non-human creatures (and the earth as a whole) are seen as irrelevant and therefore disposable. This attitude of disregard is seen in the pollution of our skies, the litter that fills our rivers and oceans, and the destruction of forests and wetlands.

KEY TERM · POPE FRANCIS

Throwaway culture.

The tendency to discard things — and people — that do not seem to have any particular usefulness. It is the shape of a world that has stopped recognizing human dignity, where anything that does not directly interest us seems to be irrelevant. Pope Francis calls the Church to reclaim its love of beauty and see true value in creation that shows us the brilliance and goodness of God.

A CULTURE OF ENCOUNTER

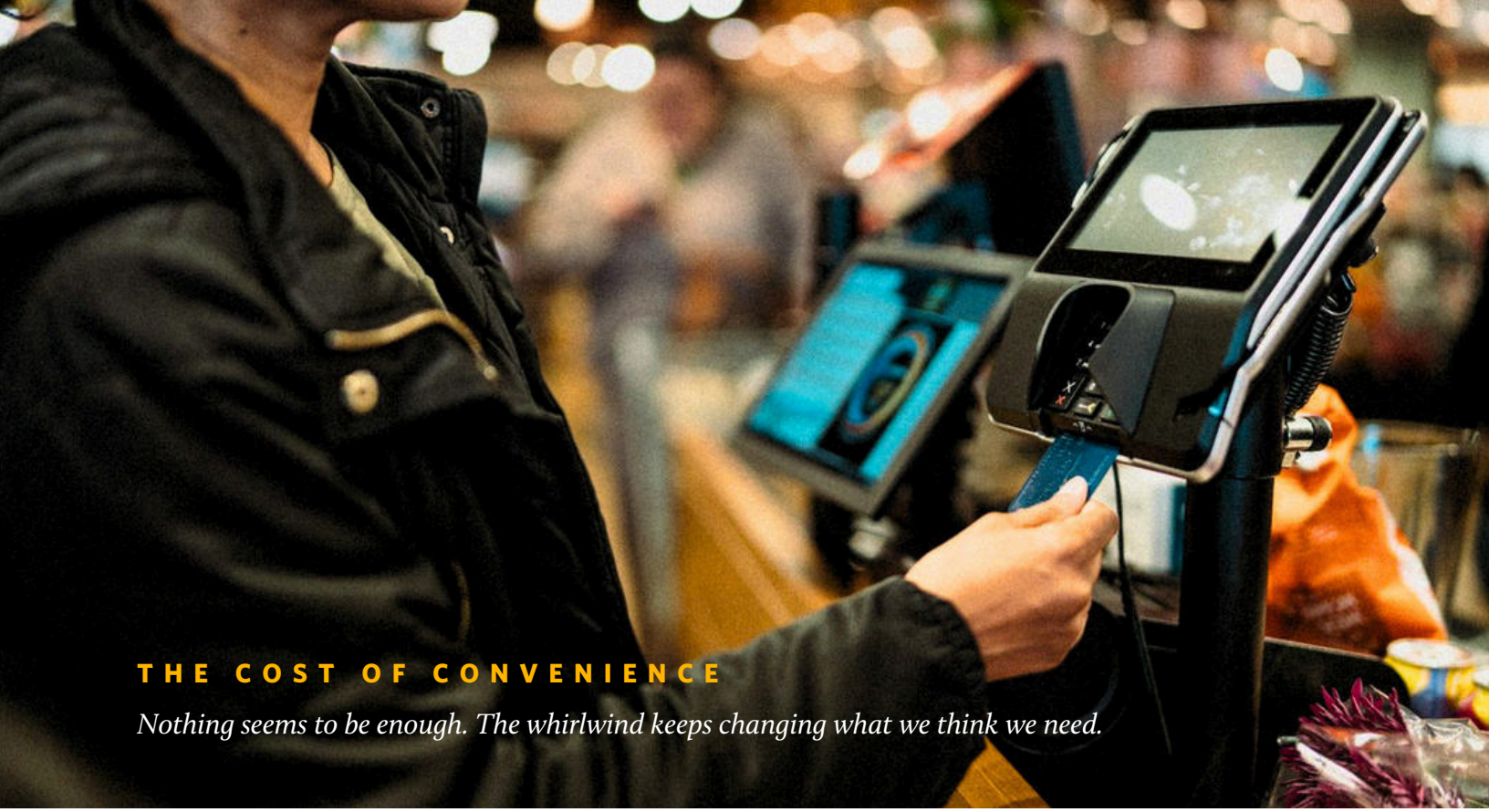
The antidote to self-centeredness begins with the smallest acts of tenderness.



FROM "I" TO "YOU"

THE ANTIDOTE

In the midst of this individualistic culture, God calls us instead to embrace a *culture of encounter*. This culture shifts us away from the mindset of "I" towards an openness to "You," which is characterized by a desire to know others and to dialogue with them, creating the possibility of love and service. This grace-filled encounter with the other must extend to the rest of God's creation as well. It is by learning to focus on ourselves less and open ourselves to others that we can create space for life to flourish as God intended.



THE COST OF CONVENIENCE

Nothing seems to be enough. The whirlwind keeps changing what we think we need.

II. THE PROBLEM OF CONSUMERISM

LAUDATO SI' 203

Just as society is defined by a preoccupation with the individual, it is also defined by a preoccupation with things. It is clear that we are living in an age of great wealth and access to material goods: the prevalence of cars, smart phones, computers, clothing, and food products all attest to this. Modern manufacturing has created an abundance of goods, and a growing global economy has made it possible for more and more people to access them. But humanity's prosperity has come with a spiritual and ecological cost.

Pope Francis defines consumerism as the *"whirlwind of needless buying and spending,"* which has become a habit for so many of us in modern times (LS 203). Nothing seems to be enough; no amount of new or exciting goods can finally satisfy us, so we continue shopping and buying in the search for some kind of fulfillment or happiness. We buy without considering the true cost of our excessive need for things; the result is massive amounts of waste that fill landfills and overflow into our streets and waterways.

We should consider a simple question: if everyone consumed as much as I do, or if every family consumed as much as my family does, would this be sustainable? Could the planet support this? For many of us, the answer is no. The solution is to use less, to keep or reuse the things we do have, and to change the way we think about the value of things.

THE SPIRITUAL ROOT OF "NOTHING IS ENOUGH"

When things lose their *true* value.

Always keeping the spiritual side in mind, Pope Francis makes an observation about consumerism: it is tied to our inability to appreciate true beauty and value. Consumerism is connected to the throwaway culture, where things are used briefly and disposed of as soon as they become *"irrelevant"* or *"useless."* This has extended to the natural world too, encompassing much of God's creation. Entire ecosystems are destroyed when they do not serve us, or when they pose an obstacle to our projects or plans. The Holy Father calls the Church to reclaim its love of beauty and see true value not in things, but in creation that shows us the brilliance and goodness of God.

WHEN WE WANT TO BE GOD

Technology without conscience.

One of the main ideas that Pope Francis develops in *Laudato Si'* is the relationship between humanity, technology, and power, which he places at the center of the ecological crisis. He begins by acknowledging that technology has made great progress in the last two centuries, changing the landscape of the earth as well as human civilization. This has brought great progress in many areas, and it continues to bless humanity and reduce suffering around the world.

> *Strive for harmony — not mastery.*
> LAUDATO SI' 225

However, Pope Francis notes that *"our immense technological development has not been accompanied by a development in human responsibility, values and conscience"* (LS 105). Nuclear missiles, biological weapons, and other instruments of war have emerged alongside powerplants, airplanes, and cutting-edge medical treatments. Even "harmless" technologies, like electricity, computers, and robots have given us unprecedented power over nature. The result? Technology has been used to dominate the natural world.

Some power over the natural world is certainly good, as in the ability to cure diseases and communicate across long distances. But more and more, we understand ourselves to be in conflict with nature: it is often seen as an obstacle we need to overcome. Too often, we desire to have *God-like control* over the world so we can manipulate it according to our desires rather than live in harmony with it. This use of technology is not driven by values, but by convenience and the desire for power.



DISORDER FOLLOWS

When technological development is separated from Christian values, disorder and destruction can occur.

So what is the solution to our problematic relationship with technology? Pope Francis makes it clear that he is not calling us to abandon science, quench creativity, or return to the Stone Age. However, *he is calling us to strive for harmony with the natural world, which will require that we see ourselves less as the masters of the earth and more as its stewards.*

This call for harmony is not simple. Pope Francis believes that a true revolution is needed to change the direction of our world. This revolution needs to encompass individuals, families, nations, cultures, economies, and technologies. It requires a change in attitudes toward one another and toward the earth. This *"revolution"* is what Pope Francis calls *integral ecology*. In the next section, we will explore this idea and suggest some practical ways that you and your family can embrace it.



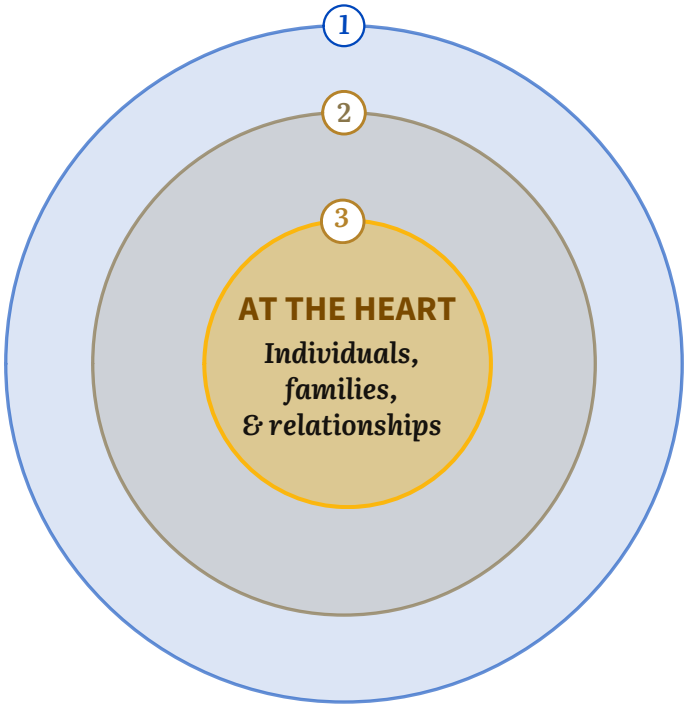
THE CULTURAL REVOLUTION

Everything is *connected.*

"Integral ecology recognizes the connection between humans, other creatures, and the larger planet. The solution must be a cultural revolution, one that changes the behaviors of individuals, nations, economies, and ultimately the global community."

INTEGRAL ECOLOGY — AT A GLANCE

Humanity and creation, *one* whole.



1 **THE EARTH**
creation · planet · ecosystems

2 **SOCIETY & COMMUNITIES**
economy · institutions · culture

3 **THE HEART**
individuals · families · relations

A whole that nests, not a hierarchy that ranks. Read from the heart outward, every family lives within communities, every community within the larger creation. Everything is connected.

POPE FRANCIS · LAUDATO SI' 138

Recognizing the interrelatedness of the ecological crisis and the many other issues affecting society, Pope Francis calls for a solution that can address all of the different aspects of these crises. His solution, which he calls the development of an *"integral ecology,"* is inspired by the science of ecology. Ecology is the study of living organisms and their relationship to the environment in which they live. It emphasizes the interrelatedness of animals and the natural world, paying attention to how they impact each other and how harmony exists among them.

Integral ecology recognizes the connection between humans, other creatures, and the larger planet, while also considering how things like the economy or politics impact society and the natural environment. The solution must be a *"cultural revolution,"* one that changes the behaviors of individuals, nations, economies, and ultimately the global community (LS 114).

PILLAR I

Concern for the *common good* rather than ourselves.

PILLAR II

Simplicity over and against the consumer mindset.

PILLAR III

Preferential *care for the poor* instead of the accumulation of wealth.

PILLAR IV

Fraternity over hostility and division.



THE CRY OF THE POOR

"Our wasted food is stolen from the table of the poor." — Laudato Si' 50

EVERYTHING IS CONNECTED

***LAUDATO SI'* 50, 138**

As we have seen, the ecological crisis has spiritual roots. Certain issues, like individualism, consumerism, and the desire for power and control are all spiritual problems. Because of this, integral ecology requires that we seek spiritual healing, the renewal of our relationships, and the transformation of our goals and desires.

Harmony is at the heart of Pope Francis' vision of integral ecology. So much of the ecological crisis has been caused by disconnection — from God, from one another, from the rest of creation, and even from ourselves. Our disconnection from each other has ultimately prevented us from seeing the dignity of human beings and other creatures. The result has been the disruption of the original harmony that God intended for the earth.

Integral ecology calls us to be mindful of how *"everything is connected"* (LS 138). As Pope Francis reminds us, environmental issues and social issues are connected, which is why the same spiritual problems can be blamed for the destruction of the natural world, the neglect of the poor, the tragedy of abortion, and other evils.

DIFFERENT ATTITUDES, DIFFERENT PRIORITIES

Everything *really* is connected.

The *"cultural revolution"* of integral ecology calls us to embrace altogether different attitudes and priorities: concern for the common good rather than ourselves, simplicity over and against the consumer mindset, preferential care for the poor instead of the accumulation of wealth, warmth and fraternity as opposed to relational coldness and division. It is a call to see God's handiwork in all creatures, to recognize the God-given dignity of our brothers and sisters, and to understand that we all come from and are returning to the Father's embrace.

Integral ecology also calls us to see the ripple effects of our actions. Our wasted food does not just have an environmental impact, but is *"stolen from the table of the poor"* (LS 50). The overcrowding of lower income neighborhoods, along with their poor living conditions, creates a sense of *"uprootedness which spawns antisocial behavior and violence"* (LS 149). Even something as simple as excessive *"screen time"* in front of cell phones and computers weakens our connection to family members, neighbors, and the natural world, thus reinforcing the spirit of self-centeredness and inattentiveness to others that has taken over our culture. Everything really is connected, and we must therefore change our lifestyles and attitudes to make a real and lasting change.



The family is the *heart* of the culture of life.

"In the face of the so-called culture of death, the family is the heart of the culture of life." — Pope Francis

Despite these challenges, Pope Francis reminds us that we can change our course and transform the world: *"Hope would have us recognize that there is always a way out, that we can always redirect our steps, that we can always do something to solve our problems"* (LS 61). Of all human communities, he believes that families play an especially important part in righting the ship. Families can and should lead the charge on behalf of humanity. The Holy Father's words are worth sharing with your family:

> "I would stress the great importance of the family, which is 'the place in which life — the gift of God — can be properly welcomed and protected against the many attacks to which it is exposed, and can develop in accordance with what constitutes authentic human growth. In the face of the so-called culture of death, the family is the heart of the culture of life.'
>
> In the family we first learn how to show love and respect for life; we are taught the proper use of things, order and cleanliness, respect for the local ecosystem and care for all creatures. In the family we receive an integral education, which enables us to grow harmoniously in personal maturity. In the family we learn to ask without demanding, to say 'thank you' as an expression of genuine gratitude for what we have been given, to control our aggressivity and greed, and to ask forgiveness when we have caused harm. These simple gestures of heartfelt courtesy help to create a culture of shared life and respect for our surroundings" (LS 213).

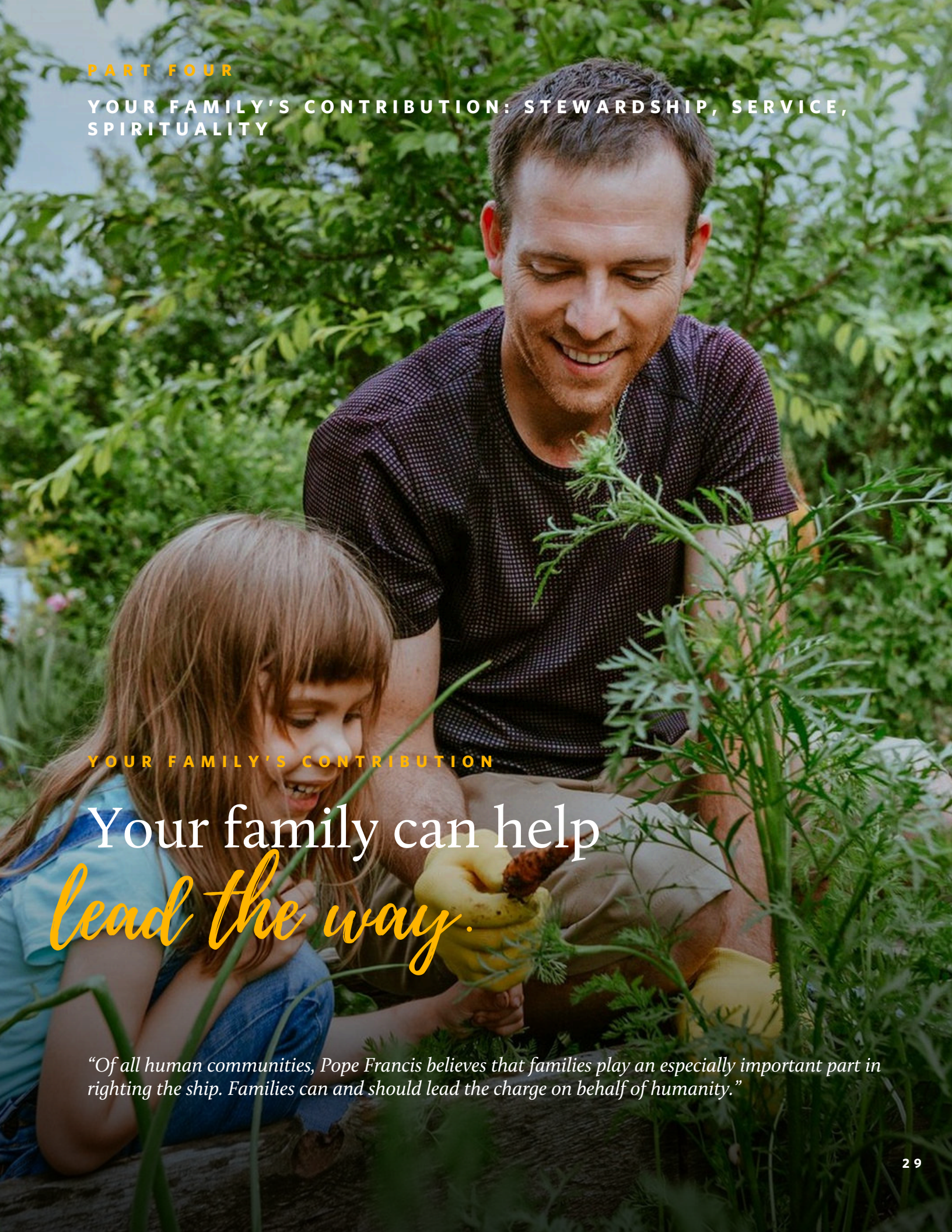
BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

Sit down *together* — and ask why.

In what follows, we would like to share a few suggestions for how your family can embrace the call to integral ecology through a commitment to stewardship and service. However, before you do, we encourage you to sit down together as a family to reflect on why you want to respond to *Laudato Si'*s call, as well as what will work best for you. It is important to be on the same page! We especially encourage you to do this in a spirit of prayer. Bring these questions to your Family Rosary, and ask for God's guidance about how you can best embrace the Holy Father's call to action.

Some of these suggestions touch on the more spiritual dimension of the call to integral ecology. Some are focused on how you can take practical steps toward harmony with God's creation and in service to those most in need. Others focus on building connections and strengthening relationships. All of them seek to strengthen your family in its love for God, for one another, and for God's creation, all the while promoting a lifestyle rooted in service and simplicity. We pray that you will find them useful as your family seeks to embrace the call to care for our common home and for one another.

It is our hope that this call to honor God by stewarding the gift of creation will unite your family in a spirit of intentional love and compassionate service. As we *"journey through this land seeking God,"* we do so with all of the rest of creation at our side (LS 244). Your family can help lead the way. May God bless you and your family, and may we never stop singing, *"Praise be to You!"*



YOUR FAMILY'S CONTRIBUTION

Your family can help *lead the way.*

"Of all human communities, Pope Francis believes that families play an especially important part in righting the ship. Families can and should lead the charge on behalf of humanity."

A NOTE FROM HCFM

Your family is *not weird* for praying together. In a world that is louder and faster every year, gathering to pray is *quietly revolutionary*.

We know how it feels. The world tells you that faith is private. That prayer is old-fashioned. That the Rosary belongs to a generation that is passing. That families have better things to do at 7:00 p.m. than light a candle. None of that is true.

What you are doing or what you are about to begin is something the world desperately needs. Every family that prays together is teaching its children that love is stronger than anger, that gratitude is stronger than frenzy, that creation is a gift and not a resource, and that God is closer than any headline. You are not old-fashioned. You are brave. You are not weird. You are generous — to your children, to your neighbors, to this common home we share.

So: take this booklet to your kitchen table. Read and use the Covenant on the next page. Try the Family Rosary resource we've included. Start small. Start tonight. And know that families across the 18 countries this ministry serves are doing the same thing. Your prayer, however small, joins theirs.

— THE EDITOR

Holy Cross Family Ministries

How to begin the Family *Rosary* tonight.

A simple five-minute guide from Holy Cross Family Ministries. One decade of the Rosary. A specific path from this page to your first family prayer. Don't wait until Sunday. Don't wait until you feel ready. Start tonight.

01 Gather your family. Anywhere.

The couch, the kitchen, the bedside. *Where you already are is where prayer begins.*

02 Light a candle (optional, but warming).

A small moment of attention. The room quiets. Phones go down.

03 Make the Sign of the Cross. Out loud, together.

"In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen."

04 Name one thing you are praying for.

Everyone says one intention aloud. *Anything* — a person, a worry, a gift, the earth, a thank-you. No rules.

05 Pray one decade of the Rosary.

Our Father (once, together) → Hail Mary (ten times) → Glory Be (once).

06 Name one thing you are grateful for.

Everyone says one gratitude aloud. End on thanks, always.

07 Make the Sign of the Cross. Blow out the candle.

"Through Him, with Him, and in Him — Amen."

That is all. Five minutes. Repeat tomorrow.

Laudato Si'.

Five questions for *your* family.

Consider the following reflection questions with your family. As you consider how you can faithfully respond to *Laudato Si'*s call to action, use these questions as a launching point for your family's discernment.

01

Environmental Stewardship as Service to Your Future Family

Consider how actively working to steward God's creation can be considered an act of love toward your future family. What kind of "common home" do you want your children's children to have? Does your family act like temporary consumers of the earth's riches, or as faithful stewards ensuring there is enough for those who come after us? Why does this matter to you and your family?

02

Recognizing the Value and Dignity of Creation

When you look at the natural world around your home — the plants and trees, the animals, even the water from your taps — do you treat these things as sacred gifts from God, or simply as utilities that you are entitled to use? How would your family's routine change if you saw every resource as a blessing on loan to you?

03

Hearing the Cry of the Earth and the Cry of the Poor

Pope Francis teaches that "everything is connected." When you look at your family's "trash" or your shopping habits, can you see the invisible thread connecting your family to people in other parts of the world? How might your choices — like what you buy or what you waste — either help or hurt your brothers and sisters who live in poverty?

04

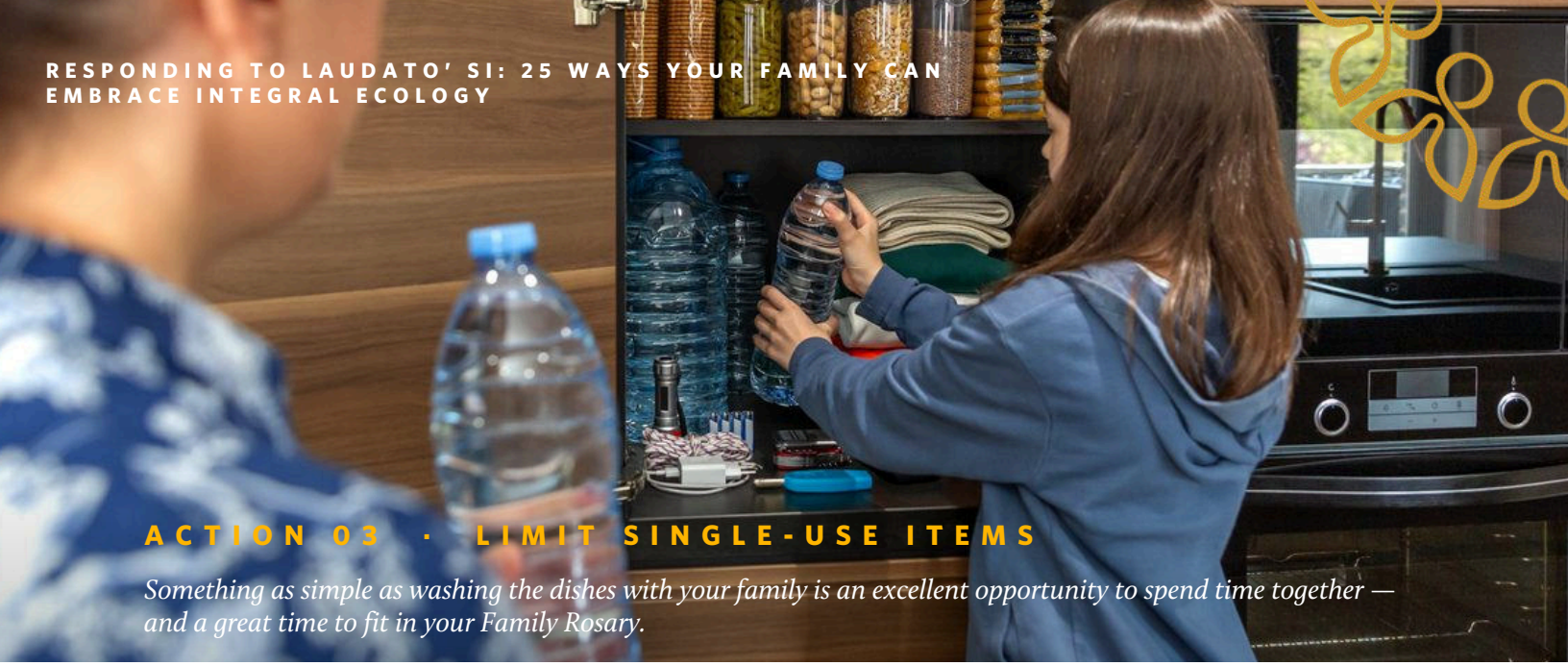
Reprioritizing Family Life

Pope Francis suggests that "less is more." Does your family's lifestyle prioritize having things or being present with one another? If you were to declutter your schedules or your home, what "spiritual space" would that open up for you to focus on God and each other? Think of some concrete ways that presence toward others rather than possession of things could improve your family's spiritual life.

05

Integral Ecology and Your Family's Prayer Life

How can your family's "green" habits — like reducing food waste, conserving energy, or spending time in nature — become an extension of your prayer life? In what ways does caring for the environment help you grow closer to God? How does it deepen your appreciation for life and foster charity toward others?



ACTION 03 · LIMIT SINGLE-USE ITEMS

Something as simple as washing the dishes with your family is an excellent opportunity to spend time together — and a great time to fit in your Family Rosary.

25 SMALL REVOLUTIONS

01 Practice a "spirituality of enough."

The great spiritual masters of the Church have all believed we should *cultivate detachment from possessions and embrace a life of simplicity*. Try to "fast" from unnecessary purchases, even if only for a week each month. This reduces our waste, breaks the cycle of consumerism, and resists the "throwaway culture."

02 Embrace meatless Fridays.

This penitential practice dates back to the earliest centuries of the Church, and is a great way to *offer a small sacrifice to God*. Consider looking at new recipes to try together.

03 Limit single-use items (like plastic water bottles, sandwich bags, straws, etc.).

Try replacing these with reusable items (dishes, napkins, water bottles, etc.). Something as simple as washing the dishes with your family is an excellent opportunity to spend time together (and it's a great time to fit in your Family Rosary).

04 Audit your family's energy and water use.

Simple practices, like taking shorter showers, unplugging appliances when they are not in use, and switching to environmentally-friendly lightbulbs all help to *lower your power and water consumption*. These practices can help to lower your family's carbon footprint, which plays an important role in cooling our planet.

05 Get involved in your parish.

See if your parish has a *Laudato Si'* initiative. If so, join it! If not, consider starting one as a family. These groups can help your parish community, as well as the wider community, *embrace Pope Francis' call to action*.



ACTION 09 · PLANT TREES AROUND YOUR COMMUNITY

Check with your local government for tree-planting days open to the public. Go with your family.

25 SMALL REVOLUTIONS

06 Build connections — and limit the distractions that separate you.

Focus on spending quality time with your loved ones. Consider creating "device-free zones" in your home, especially at the dinner table. If you watch TV in the evening, do it together as a family (and talk about what you're watching, too). Building connections within your family is the first step toward building a "culture of connection."

07 Limit your food waste.

Plan out your family's meals in advance and *make use of leftovers*. Consider composting organic waste for a vegetable garden or flower bed.

08 Organize or join a community clean up.

This is especially needed in natural areas where litter affects wildlife (like creeks or rivers). *Offer this clean up as an act of love and gratitude to God* for His gift of creation.

09 Plant trees around your home, community, or city.

Check with your local government to see if there are any *tree planting days* that are open to the public. Go with your family!

10 Landscape with native species.

If your family has a garden, consider *planting flowers, shrubs, and tree species that are native to your area*. These often grow naturally without the need of excess water. They also help support local bee and butterfly populations, which play a crucial role in pollination and the health of local plant life.



ACTION 12 · CLEAN DRINKING WATER
Responding to both the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor.



ACTION 14 · FAMILY VEGETABLE GARDEN
Get in touch with the earth — and feed the hungry.

25 SMALL REVOLUTIONS

11 Resist the "throwaway culture" by reusing and recycling.

Recycle if it is possible in your area, and reuse old items (especially for things like grocery bags or food containers). If possible, fix broken items rather than buying new ones. Consider e-recycling old electronic appliances to prevent harmful chemicals from leaching into the environment.

12 Support access to clean drinking water.

Support organizations like Catholic Relief Services or Water.org, which provide developing countries with access to clean drinking water and sanitation infrastructure. This is a great way to heed Pope Francis' call to listen to both "the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor."

13 Consider supporting eco-charities in your charitable giving.

As part of your family's almsgiving, *consider donating* to services that support conservation, environmental clean ups, reforestation efforts, or other environmentally-focused good works. As Pope Benedict XVI reminded us, how we spend our money always has a moral dimension.

14 Start a family vegetable garden and donate a portion of your harvest to a local food pantry.

Growing your own vegetables is a great way to get in touch with the earth and cut back on food packaging. *Giving part of your harvest to the hungry* is a great way to practice integral ecology.

15 Embrace an "ecological spirituality."

Cultivate your sense of wonder and appreciation of creation's beauty. Commit to savoring the beauty of the world — do this intentionally each day. Consider saying one Rosary each week outside (if weather permits). This helps us to appreciate God's creation apart from its usefulness to us.

16 Carpool as much as possible.

Carpooling helps to reduce carbon emissions and is a great way to spend quality time with your family. And car rides are always a great time to pray together!

17 Do one act of service for each of your family members every day.

Building a habit of self-sacrifice is essential to breaking out of self-centeredness and increasing our attentiveness to others and the wider world.

18 Educate yourself and your family about the natural world.

Begin by *learning about the earth and the creatures with whom we share it*. Concern for creation begins with appreciating its beauty and grandeur.

19 Practice finding joy apart from material things.

Relish the joy that comes from relationships, service, music, art, nature, prayer, and developing your God-given gifts. This can help to *break the grip of consumerism* from our lives.

20 Step out of the frenzy from time to time.

Practice simple presence and attentiveness to others, with a focus on appreciating the here and now. This breaks us out of the anxiety that causes confrontational attitudes, lowers our desire for distractions, and helps us to *appreciate the simple things in life*. This can help us to live simply, honestly, and charitably.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The "cultural revolution" of integral ecology calls us to embrace altogether different attitudes and priorities — simplicity over and against the consumer mindset, warmth and fraternity as opposed to relational coldness and division.



ACTION 22 · SAY GRACE BEFORE MEALS

Appreciate the gift of creation — and remember our reliance on God.



ACTION 24 · BEAUTIFY A PUBLIC SPACE

Simple acts of public service break us out of our individualism.

25 SMALL REVOLUTIONS

21 Embrace the "First and Last Rule."

Avoid screens for the first 30 minutes after waking and the last 30 minutes before bed. This ensures that the first and last "voices" your family member hears are those of their loved ones, not a device. *Practicing temperance with our technology* tames our consumeristic tendencies and ensures that real relationships, especially with our family members, stay in the foreground every day.

22 Always say grace before meals.

Pray as a family, with a different family member leading each night. This practice *helps us to appreciate the gift of creation and reminds us of our reliance on God* and His creation to sustain us.

23 Take the "little way of love" with your family members.

St. Thérèse of Lisieux believed that little acts of love were the fastest way to holiness. Serve your family members, prioritize them over yourself, and always remind them of how much you love them. *This makes our homes places of peace, humility, and selflessness.*

24 Participate in the beautification of a public space like a park, plaza, or town square.

Pope Francis said that *simple acts of public service like this break us out of our individualism* and create a sense of shared identity. Take pride in your neighborhood!

25 Reclaim the centrality of the Sabbath in your family's life.

Break out of the habit of constant working, buying, and spending. Use this day to attend Mass and to pray with your family. Reclaim the tradition of the Sunday family dinner. *Spend time outdoors, and learn to appreciate that God's creation is "very good."* This is an essential way to reconnect with God, with our families, and with the world around us.

HOLY CROSS
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A FINAL WORD

The family that prays together, stays together.

VENERABLE PATRICK PEYTON

May the families who hold this guide find courage to gather, to listen, and to begin. Across eighteen countries and twenty-nine ministry centers, you are not praying alone — you are praying with all of us.

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